

Step 1 Evaluation Report

CONFIDENTIAL

Call reference	ERC-2024-ADG
Activity	HORIZON ERC Grants
Funding scheme	ERC ADVANCED GRANTS
Panel name	SH5
Proposal No.	101201459
Acronym	MARGINS
Applicant Name	Avriel BAR-LEVAV
Title	Inside the Hebrew Book: Perspectives from the Margins

EVALUATION CRITERIA

Criterion 1 - RESEARCH PROJECT

Ground-breaking nature and potential impact of the research project

To what extent does the proposed research address important challenges?

To what extent are the objectives ambitious and beyond the state of the art (e.g. novel concepts and approaches or development between or across disciplines)?

Scientific Approach

To what extent is the outlined scientific approach feasible bearing in mind the ground-breaking nature and ambition of the proposed research (based on the Extended Synopsis)?

Criterion 2 - PRINCIPAL INVESTIGATOR

Intellectual capacity and creativity

To what extent has the PI demonstrated the ability to conduct ground-breaking research?

To what extent does the PI provide evidence of creative and original thinking?

To what extent does the PI have the required scientific expertise and capacity to successfully execute the project?

PANEL SCORE AND RANKING RANGE

Final panel score: B (is of high quality but not sufficient to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation. Please note that you may also be subject to resubmission limitations in the next call)	Ranking range*: 61%-76% For your information, only the top 30% of the proposals evaluated in panel SH5 were retained for Step 2.
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* Ranking range of your proposal out of the proposals evaluated by the panel in Step 1, in percent, from 1% for the highest ranked proposals to 100% for the lowest ranked.

PANEL COMMENT

This evaluation report contains the final score awarded by the ERC review panel during the first step of the ERC Advanced Grant review and the ranking range. The discussion of the panel was conducted within the context of the individual reviews submitted by ERC panel members.

The panel closely examined all the individual review reports and, while not necessarily subscribing to each and every opinion expressed, found that they provide a fair overall assessment. The comments of the individual reviewers were the basis for the discussion and the final recommendation of the panel, and are included in this report.

The PI is aptly qualified to undertake this research and has a solid record of publications. The proposal sets out to work in an important area of scholarship focusing on textual and paratextual elements in early modern Hebrew print, which has been largely neglected. However, the panel found that the proposal lacked a comparative literature review. The panel also considered that the scientific approach was insufficiently explained.

Overall, the panel considers this proposal to be of good quality. However, based on the combined set of criteria used in the assessment it was not sufficient to be retained for Step 2. The panel therefore recommends that the proposal should not be retained for Step 2 and should not be considered for funding.

REVIEWER COMMENTS

The following individual reviews have been carried out independently prior to the panel meeting and do not necessarily reflect the panel's final opinion

Reviewer 1

Research Project

Ground-breaking nature and potential impact of the research project

The project contributes to the burgeoning field of material text studies, focusing on an area that so far has been relatively unstudied, namely early modern Hebrew book printing. It involves the first systematic and comprehensive study of three aspects pertaining to the printing of early modern Hebrew books: fonts or typefaces, graphic elements, and paratexts. The project is guided by questions relating to the identification and understanding of the cultural streamlines involved, the networks of agents, and the Jewish paratextual discourse. While the bibliography mentions some broader studies on the history of book printing, the project's focus remains limited to Hebrew books. There is no attempt at developing a more comparative perspective, which would seem to make much sense, now that material text studies is developing into an independent field of study, and Hebrew book printing did not take place in isolation.

Scientific Approach

The project will make it possible to identify and locate centers of printing and establish relations and contacts between the various agents of bookmaking involved, thus laying out printers' networks in the early modern period. The research will involve a combination of material (simply put: visual and textual) and will be done through digital text analysis. It is not clear to what extent library visits and research, OCR scanning, etc will be required. The project's main outcome will be an interactive platform that will be made public at the end of the project, and which will involve a team of analysts working cooperatively on a daily basis. The team will require a combination of technical skill and linguistic/cultural-historical knowledge, but that should be manageable.

Principal Investigator

Intellectual capacity and creativity

The PI is a specialist of Jewish culture with a prime interest in Jewish book history, in particular the printing of peripheral works, and has an extensive publication record. The PI has some experience with PhD and Postdoc supervision. The PI has also organized several conferences and workshops. There is no mention of having been in charge of a major research project before

Reviewer 2

Research Project

Ground-breaking nature and potential impact of the research project

This attractive project offers to fill important gaps in our collective knowledge of printed books, within the niche area of Hebrew printing. One engaging aspect of the proposal is 'dynamic modeling', studying the physical layout of printed pages, fonts, title pages, and other aspects of book culture, but because existing models are based upon preconceived categories taken from non-Hebrew books, the proposal anticipates different conclusions from those anticipated in the initial stages of the word.

Scientific Approach

A positive feature of this proposal are bi-weekly reading sessions for team members for study of all aspects of printing, to pool the collective expertise of team members. The machine learning and digital platforms involved in this project are described as readily available, 'trained on previous datasets', and one has to assume that this is the case. The description of work packets is somewhat vague, since the main philological and codicological work appear to be concentrated in year one, with machine-based work in years two and three, and the final two years devoted to analysis of results. This description of the project timetable appears unbalanced and unrealistic, and one expects fuller descriptions in B2.

Principal Investigator

Intellectual capacity and creativity

The PI's commitment to the proposed project is clear from publications dealing with aspects of libraries and book culture with Jewish contexts, although the majority of relevant publications consists of articles rather than monograph-length studies. While the PI has supervised doctoral research, there is no apparent experience of participating in funded teamwork projects.

Reviewer 3

Research Project

Ground-breaking nature and potential impact of the research project

The project proposes to categorize and analyse the non-textual elements and paratexts of Hebrew books from the 15th to the 18th centuries. The study of such aspects in large corpora with recourse to digital tools is now a very fashionable field in book history. The proposed side-focus on broadsheets is a very fine idea; the digital observation of one-side prints can be automatized for the comprehensive classification of their layout and typography more straightforward than for books. It is however somewhat difficult to assess the objectives' relation to today's state of the art for the reason that the application only very sparingly references previous scholarship to contextualize its premises and propositions.

Scientific Approach

The annual work plan seems feasible although it could be more detailed. The planned use of digital tools such as Transkribus and eScriptorium would allow for sweeping analyses across the very large materials to be studied. That proposal could likewise be more in depth (even though the progress in the field is fast such that very meticulous pre-arrangement wouldn't be beneficial). The overall lack in detail applies also to the description of expected results other than the database. The allocation of tasks is discussed in somewhat imprecise terms.

Principal Investigator

Intellectual capacity and creativity

The PI is an experienced scholar with a remarkable publication record. His publications from the last ten year include, inter alia, ten single-authored and edited volumes. While the application does not mention previous experience as a project PI, but the PI has had other leadership jobs and supervisory assignments, which shows that he'd be fully capable of directing the proposed project. The PI is also an experienced collaborator, an asset here as the research task to be undertaken requires much teamwork.

Reviewer 4

Research Project

Ground-breaking nature and potential impact of the research project

In recent times, studies in print and book culture have emerged in different parts of the world, especially in an attempt to capture how both visual and textual aspects can enable a sharper understanding of given book histories and related print culture at foundational moments. This makes this project on Jewish print culture important, but certainly not novel; it is an extension of what has now become a popular field across the globe. Its novelty though, may well reside in the limited attention that has been paid to Jewish books, but certainly not in the nature of work envisaged here in terms of the focus of study. It is, nevertheless, the scope of this project that makes it significant, especially in understanding early modern Jewish culture through the prism of textual and physical elements of the printed book.

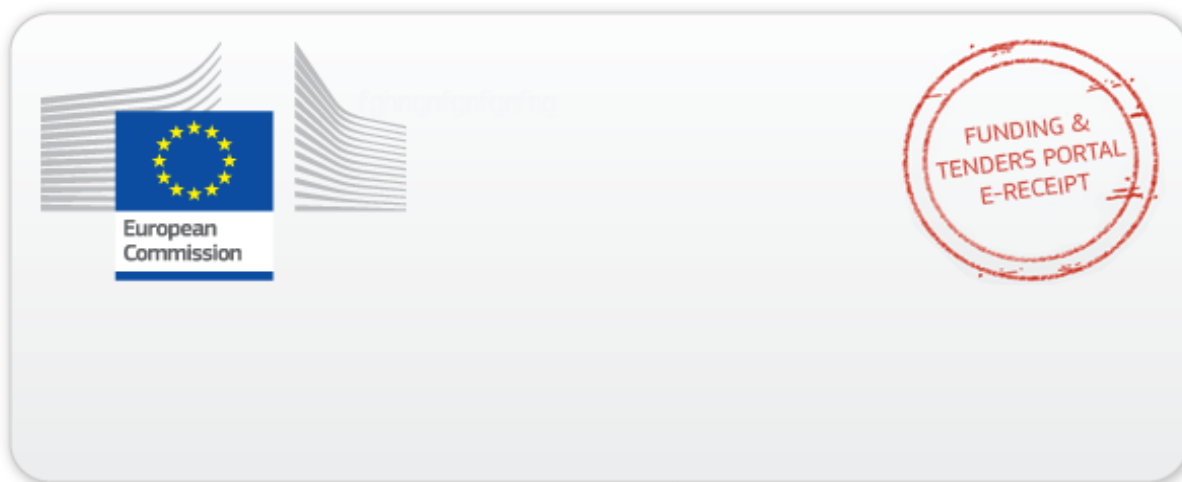
Scientific Approach

The approach outlined here over the five-year period the project will be undertaken is certainly commensurate with the challenges posed in the proposal. These are both archival and close reading of available texts. I wondered though whether this is an easy task, given the sheer volume of texts referred to here, which are in upper thousands.

Principal Investigator

Intellectual capacity and creativity

The PI is aptly qualified for this project and has done work in the same area at a small scale. He will require a huge team to accomplish what is envisaged here. The potential to undertake path-breaking work is there, although work on print culture is not entirely new and is very much in vogue in many cultures. The Hebrew dimension is likely to add a new dimension to the print culture of one of the world's oldest languages.



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